MOREH NEVUCHIM

Heard, Not Seen: Avar, Ba & the Voice That Passed Before Moshe

Given Tuesday 27 October 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim I:21-22

Sefer: Moreh Nevuchim (Rambam), Chelek Aleph — Rabbi Chaim Makbili's Hebrew edition / Sefaria

Chapters: I:21 — **עבר** (to pass), Part 3 (conclusion); I:22 — **בא** (to come)

Topic: The Rambam's **fourth interpretation** of **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא** — adding the word **קול**, *the voice of Hashem passed*, which makes **ה' ה'** a doubled call; the Rambam's summary: **"choose whichever you want"** — so long as you never think God physically passed; Rav Makbili's ranking of the four, from the most intellectual to the most physical; reading the whole passage of Ki Tisa four ways; **the four questions answered**, with the full comparison chart; the **טעמים**; why not to **count the Thirteen Attributes on your fingers**; **עבירה** and **המעביר על מדותיו**; and **Chapter 22**: the four meanings of **בא**, and what it means for Hashem to "come"

Schedule note: The Moreh continues every Tuesday, 8:00–9:00pm. Chapter 21 is now complete; Chapter 22 was learned in the last 15 minutes. Next week: Chapters 23, 24 and (b'ezrat Hashem) 25.

Recap: Where We Are

Chapter 21 explains the word **עבר**, in order to explain **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא** (Shemot 34:6) — and with it the whole dialogue between Moshe and HaKadosh Baruch Hu in **Parashat Ki Tisa**.

The five meanings of עבר

#	Meaning	Example
1	To physically pass something; movement across space	**והוא עבר לפניהם**
2	To proclaim — a voice or sound spreading, reverberating	**ויעבירו קול במחנה**
3	A prophetic vision passing through a person's imagination	**ולפיד אש אשר עבר בין הגזרים**
4	To overreach — to go beyond the boundaries	**וכגבר עברו יין**
5	To divert — to skip one thing and move to another	**והוא ירה החצי להעברו**

The three interpretations so far

#	Whose reading	means עבר	What happened
1	**The Rambam's own, preferred**	**5 — diversion**	Hashem diverted Moshe from **God's own face** (His essence) to His **back**; **ויקרא ה'** — and Hashem called the Thirteen Attributes, which *are* the back of God: the way He operates in this world
2	**Targum Onkelos, simple reading (2A)**	**1 — physical passing**	Onkelos adds a word: a **created, physical manifestation** — the Shechinah, the kavod — passed **Moshe's** face; then Hashem called. *(This is why people bow their heads at ויעבר — as if the glory is passing over us.)*
3	**Targum Onkelos, deeper reading (2B)**	**3 — prophetic vision**	The glory of Hashem passed **in Moshe's mind**, through a **נבואה**; and Hashem called the attributes in that prophecy

So far we have used עבר 1, עבר 5 and עבר 3. Now comes the fourth and final interpretation — which uses **עבר 2**.

The key to it: the Targum (and Rav Saadia Gaon, as we saw) is content to **add words into a verse**, especially in the context of HaKadosh Baruch Hu. The Rambam says: my preferred explanation is the first one — **עבר** as diversion, which needs no added word. *But if you want to use the Targum's principle, I'll use it too — and add a different word.*

Part One — Interpretation 4: "The Voice of Hashem Passed"

The Rambam's text

ומוכרח לפרש באופן של השמטת הנסמך כדרכו של אונקלוס תמיד, שלעתים מפרש שהמלה המושמטת היא כבוד — יקרא, ולעתים שכינה, ולעתים מימרא, כל מקום כפי ענינו —

If we are going to follow Onkelos's interpretive method — supplying a missing word, which he does constantly, sometimes **יקרא** (glory), sometimes **שכינה**, sometimes **מימרא** (word), each according to its context —

הרי שאנחנו גם כן נפרש, שהנסמך המושמט כאן הוא קול.

— then **we too** will supply a missing word here: not **שכינה** or **כבוד**, but **קול**, *voice*.

ויעבר קול ה' על פניו ויקרא — וכך יש לקרוא.

This is how you read the verse: **the voice of Hashem passed** in the presence of Moshe, **and it called** — the voice called.

וכבר ביארנו את ההשאלה בלשון של העברה ביחס לקול: ויעבירו קול במחנה. לפי זה, הקול הוא אשר קרא.

This is **meaning 2** of **עבר**: a proclamation, a reverberation — just as Moshe "passed a voice" through the camp, *stop bringing donations for the Mishkan*. On this reading, the voice of Hashem **reverberated over the presence of Moshe** — **על פניו** — and the **voice** is what called.

The reading of the verse — and the double ה'

(The Rabbi skipped paragraph 12 to read paragraph 13 first, then came back.)

הפירוש לפי הקריאה הזו יהיה אם כן כך: ועבר קול מלפני ה' בנוכחותו של משה, וקרא: ה' ה'.

A voice from before Hashem passed — reverberated — in Moshe's presence, and called out: **"ה', ה', אל רחום וחנון..."**

וכפילות ה' תהא עבור הקריאה, משום שהוטלה בו קריאה — כמו משה משה, אברהם אברהם. וגם זה פירוש נאה מאוד.

This changes how the verse divides. Until now — in interpretations 1, 2 and 3 — **ויקרא** always went with the next word: **ויקרא ה'**, *and Hashem called*. That is why we said last week that **ה' ה'** does not go together: the first **ה'** is the one calling, and what He called begins with the second.

But now the verse reads **ויעבר קול ה' על פניו, ויקרא** — *and the voice called* — so the subject of **ויקרא** is the voice, and **ה' ה'** is what it called: **a doubled expression**, the way one calls out a name twice — **משה משה** (Shemot 3:4), **אברהם אברהם** (Bereishit 22:11). *"And this, too, is a very fine interpretation."*

What this shows us: the Rambam understands all the other interpretations **without** a double Hashem. **Only on reading 4 is there a double ה' ה'.** And this is the reading reflected in how we say it in shul — on Yom Kippur, and whenever we say the Thirteen Attributes: **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא — ה' ה'...**, as if the doubled Name is part of the attributes. (More on this below.)

Paragraph 12: a voice that speaks, a voice that calls

אל ירחק בעיניך ייחוס הקריאה לקול.

Don't think it strange that I attribute *calling* to a voice —

> **כי במילים האלה עצמן סופר על דברי ה' עם משה: וישמע את הקול מדבר אליו.** (Parashat Naso, Bamidbar 7:89 — the end of)

— the Torah itself describes Hashem's speech with Moshe this way: **Moshe heard the voice speaking to him. Just as speech is attributed to the voice, so calling can be attributed to the voice.** In Naso the voice *speaks*; here in Ki Tisa the voice *calls*.

And another example: קול אמר קרא, ואמר מה אקרא (Yeshayahu 40:6) — *a voice says, "Call!" and he said, "What shall I call?"* Again, a voice in the context of calling.

A side point for those who love dikduk: מְדַבֵּר

וישמע את הקול מדבר אליו — a very interesting, very peculiar, very rare word.

What it looks like	An ordinary **פיעל**, **מְדַבֵּר** — *speaking*
What it really is	**מְדַבֵּר** = **מִתְדַּבֵּר**, a **התפעל** — *speaking to itself*
The grammar	The **ת** of the hitpael falls away, and the **דגש** in the second letter, the **ד**, replaces the missing **ת**
The meaning (Rashi)	**God speaks to Himself.** He doesn't speak *to* humans — you listen in

This is what the Rambam talks about at length in many places: prophecy is **tuning in**. There is a beam — a prophecy, a calling, a speaking, a light — coming down constantly, and it is, as it were, talking to itself. **It is up to you to come into that beam**, to come into that prophecy, to tune in. That is the meaning of **מְדַבֵּר**.

Part Two — The Rambam Concludes: "Choose Whichever You Want"

Don't be disturbed

אל יהא מגונה בעיניך קיומם של פירושים רבים לעניין הקשה הזה.

Calm down. Don't be disturbed that I have now given you **four ways** to read a single verse in the Torah, each using a different meaning of **עבר**. Perhaps you'll think, *what does this verse mean? Stop confusing me!* — No, it shouldn't disturb you. There is nothing wrong with that.

ואתה בחר אחת מהסברות.

The Rambam gives us permission: whenever you read these verses — every morning in Shacharit, at Mincha, when we read the Torah, on Yom Kippur — **you choose one of the four.**

The four options, in the Rambam's words

1. The Rambam's own reading (עבר 5)

אם שיהיה מעמד הגדול זה כולו במראה נבואה בלא ספק, וכל השאיפה של משה — השגה שכלית, שביקש ושנמנעה ממנו, ומה שהשיג — הכל שכלי, בלי שום חוש, כמשפט שבתחילה.

The entire great event is a prophetic vision; Moshe's whole desire was a deep **intellectual** understanding of God — to see His face; that was withheld, but he did attain God's back. **Completely intellectual — no physical sense at all.** A complete intellectual journey.

2. Onkelos, simple reading (עבר 1)

או שיחד עם זאת הייתה השגת חוש הראייה על דבר נברא, שבראייתו מושגת שלמות השגה שכלית — כמשפט אונקלוס.

Or, together with that, there was **a perception by sight** of **a created thing**: Hashem created a physical manifestation, it passed Moshe, and **that is what Moshe saw** — a corporeal, physical, created manifestation of HaKadosh Baruch Hu.

3. Onkelos, deeper reading (עבר 3)

אלא אם השגת הראייה הזאת הייתה גם היא במראה נבואה, כפי שנאמר אצל אברהם: והנה תנור עשן ולפיד אש אשר עבר בין הגזרים האלה.

Or this "seeing" was itself **in a prophetic vision** — like the smoke and fire passing between the pieces at the Brit Bein HaBetarim, which (as we saw) happened in Avraham's mind. The Shechinah passed in Moshe's imagination.

4. The Rambam using Onkelos's principle (עבר 2)

או שיחד עם זאת הייתה השגת חוש שמיעה גם כן, וזה הקול אשר עבר על פניו.

Or there was a perception by **hearing**: **a created voice** reverberated in Moshe's presence, and that voice called **ה' ה'**.

The one thing that matters

בחר איזה דעה שתחפוץ — כי כל המטרה היא שלא תחשוב שעבר כפשוטו... כי ה' יתעלה ויתרומם אינו גוף, ולא שייך בו תנועה.

Choose whichever you want — "I don't care." The whole purpose is that you should **not** read **ויעבר** as meaning 1 applied to **God Himself** — God actually passing — **because Hashem has no body, and**

movement cannot apply to Him. That is impossible.

The Rabbi: *if there is one thing we take from this chapter, it is the Rambam's conclusion — there is no physical passing and no physical face, because God has no corporeality.*

Rav Makbili: the four are a ladder

You could say the Rambam simply lists the four **in the order he explained them**. But Rav Makbili points out something beautiful: **the order is a choice offered by level.**

Level	Reading	Sense	Why it sits here
Highest	**1 — The Rambam's own**	**Intellect only**	The most non-corporeal: a complete dialogue in Moshe's mind about trying to understand God. **The best of the four — clearly the Rambam's preference**
Lowest	**2 — Onkelos, simple**	**Sight** of a created glory	If the first is too hard for you, I'll bring you "all the way back down": the most fleshed-out, most corporeal reading — an actual, created glory of God passing Moshe. *"I don't want to say it's the worst — but it's the most physical one."*
In between	**3 — Onkelos, prophetic**	**Prophetic vision**	You've gone beyond understanding things physically, but you're not yet ready for reading 1: the Shechinah passing in Moshe's mind
In between	**4 — The voice**	**Hearing**	Also for one who has moved beyond the corporeal: **a voice is very subtle**, much more subtle than sight — it's not so physical

"How beautiful!" — **Extreme one** is reading 1; **extreme two** is reading 2; and **3 and 4** are for the person in between.

Part Three — Reading Ki Tisa Four Ways

The Rabbi then went through the verses quickly **according to all four interpretations**. *("Follow with me.")*

The common opening: ויאמר: הראני נא את כבדך — Moshe asks, "Show me Your glory, Your face." Hashem says: you can't see My face; no human can. **הנה מקום אתי, ונצבת על הצור** — if you want intellectual standing, **מקום**, constantly think about God, the origin of all.

The passage, reading by reading

Verse	1 — Rambam (diversion)	2 — Onkelos simple (physical)	3 — Onkelos deeper (prophecy)	4 — Rambam / voice (proclamation)
והיה בעבר כבדי (33:22)	When **I Myself** (כבודי = God Himself) **divert** you from My face to My back	When My **created, physical, manifested glory** passes you	When My glory passes **in your mind** — when you experience the prophetic vision	When **My voice** passes you
ושמתיך בנקרת הצור, ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי	I will give you **intellectual protection** throughout the diversion, so you don't get intellectually burnt — die or go mad, like the four who entered the Pardes	A **physical** guarding: not literally God's palm, but I'll protect you from the created light — it's very scary, even though it isn't God Himself	I will guard you so you **don't get burnt while experiencing the prophetic vision**	It's a scary voice, a strong voice — God's voice — so I'll cover you with My metaphorical palm
והסרתי את כפי, וראית את אחרי	Then you will see My back — My attributes, the way I act	You'll see the **back of the glory** — "My back," as it were — but never My face, God Himself	—	—
וירד ה' בענן, ויתיצב עמו שם (34:5)	Hashem rests His presence on the "thickness" of the human Moshe (**ענן** — see Chapter 22), in permanent dialogue	—	—	—
ויעבר ה' על פניו (34:6)	God **diverted** Moshe from God's face to God's back	God's created glory **passed Moshe's presence**	The Shechinah **passed in Moshe's mind**, in prophecy	**The voice of Hashem reverberated** in Moshe's presence
ויקרא	**ויקרא ה'** — *and Hashem called:*	Hashem — **ויקרא ה'** called, through the physical manifestation:	the — **ויקרא ה'** prophecy called:	**ויקרא** — *and the voice called:*
What was called	**"ה' אל רחום וחנון, ארך אפים ורב חסד ואמת..."** — the Thirteen Attributes, the back of God	**"ה' אל רחום וחנון..."**	**"ה' אל רחום וחנון..."**	**"ה', ה', אל רחום וחנון..."** — a doubled call

The Rabbi's note on verse 23 (thinking aloud): on the Rambam's reading there is a small difficulty — the verse says *I will remove My palm, and then you will see My back.* If the palm is intellectual protection, why remove it before seeing the back? He answered that **וראית את אחרי** may mean *and you will have seen My back* — the diversion is over. (Doron then offered a better answer — see Part Five.)

Part Four — The Four Questions, Answered

When we began this chapter (at the end of the shiur two weeks ago), the Rabbi asked four questions. Now we can answer them all.

The comparison chart

The Rabbi asked: "Doron, if we can get an AI chart of all of these four meanings, with the **נפקא מינות** — in terms of Hashem, in terms of His face, in terms of **עבר**, in terms of who called, in terms of the passing of **בעבור כבודי** — I think that would be amazing… so we've got it visually in front of us."

	1 — The Rambam's own reading	2 — Onkelos, simple (2A)	3 — Onkelos, deeper (2B)	4 — The Rambam, using Onkelos's principle
Word added to the verse?	None	*the* — **שכינה / יקרא** *glory*	— **שכינה / יקרא** *the glory*	*the voice* — **קול**
Meaning of עבר	**5 — diversion**	**1 — physical passing**	**3 — prophetic vision**	**2 — proclamation / reverberation**
What "passed"?	Nothing passed: **Hashem diverted Moshe** from His face to His back	A **created, physical** glory of God	The **Shechinah in Moshe's mind**	A **created voice**
Whose face (פניו)?	**God's face**	**Moshe's** — *in his presence*	**Moshe's** — *in his presence*	**Moshe's** — *in his presence*
Who called (ויקרא)?	**Hashem** — **ויקרא ה'**	**Hashem** — **ויקרא ה'**	**Hashem** — **ויקרא ה'**	**The voice** — **ויקרא**
ה' ה' — doubled?	**No** — the first ה' is the caller	**No**	**No**	**Yes** — a doubled call, like **משה משה**
בעבר כבדי	**כבודי** = God Himself; **בעבר** = *when I divert you*	When My **created glory** physically passes	When My glory passes **in your mind**	When **My voice** passes
ושכתי כפי עליך	**Intellectual** protection during the diversion	**Physical** protection from the created light	Protection **in the mind** during the vision	Protection from a **strong, awesome voice**
Sense involved	**Intellect alone** — no physical sense	**Sight**	**Prophetic imagination**	**Hearing**
Rav Makbili's ladder	**Highest** — most non-corporeal	**Lowest** — most physical	**Middle**	**Middle** — a voice is subtle
Bowing at ויעבר	Nothing to bow for (last week)	Makes sense — the glory passes before you	—	—
Fits the טעמים?	Not so well	Not so well	Not so well	**Yes** — the pause comes after **ויקרא**
First ה' one of the 13 attributes?	**No**	**No**	**No**	**No** — the doubling is "for beauty," as it were, not an attribute

Question 1 — What does עבר mean?

It depends on the reading: Rambam (1) — meaning **5**, diversion; Targum simple (2) — meaning **1**, physical passing; Targum deeper (3) — meaning **3**, prophetic imagination; Rambam with Targum's principle (4) — meaning **2**, reverberation and proclamation.

Question 2 — Whose face?

On **reading 1**, the Rambam's preferred, **פניו** is **God's face**. On **readings 2, 3 and 4** — both readings of the Targum and the Rambam's fourth — **פניו** is **Moshe's** face, i.e. *his presence*.

A question from the class: why can't Moshe see God's face?

Because God has no face. "God's face" means **the very deep and intimate understanding of God**, which is impossible for a human to comprehend. I can look at another human being, study their face, look into their eyes, and come to know them — **that is not possible with HaKadosh Baruch Hu.**

"What about looking at Him from far?" — There is nothing to look at, because there is **nothing physical** to look at. That's the whole point.

"Even like a storm, or like lightning?" — No. God is far more encompassing than that. **Whatever you try to limit God into is limited** — even if it is the biggest thing in the world, it still has a framework; it is still physical.

Question 3 — How do we read ה' ויקרא?

Readings	How the verse divides
1, 2 and 3	"*...and Hashem called*: "Hashem, merciful God — **ויעבר ה' על פניו — ויקרא ה': "ה' אל רחום וחנון..."**
4	"*...and [the voice] called*: "Hashem, Hashem — **ויעבר ה' על פניו, ויקרא: "ה' ה' אל רחום וחנון..."**

The טעמים

As Doron pointed out last week, the cantillation fits **reading 4** much better: **ויקרא** carries a **זרקא**, and **ה' ה'** follows with a **סגולתא** — **there is a pause after ויקרא**. On readings 1, 2 and 3 you would expect the verse to run **ויקרא ה'** together.

And Doron sent the Rabbi a source during the week: Ibn Ezra already asks this — because **Rav Saadia Gaon** also read it **ויקרא ה'**, *and Hashem called*, and Ibn Ezra asks: if so, the טעמים should reflect it.

The Rabbi's assessment: this is a registered, very early question on readings 1, 2 and 3. **It's not a huge question**, because the טעמים are very, very late, so he isn't too worried. But it is important to recognize that the טעמים are not so "glatt" — not so clean — according to readings 1, 2 and 3.

Question 4 — The Thirteen Attributes: don't count them on your fingers

A halachic point the Rabbi wanted to bring out.

How we sing it in shul — whether **עדות המזרח** or S&P, everyone does the same: **ויקרא בשם ה', שנאמר: ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא, ה', ה', אל רחום וחנון, ארך אפים, ורב חסד ואמת, נוצר חסד לאלפים, נושא עון ופשע וחטאה, ונקה.**

Approach	Source	Is the first ה' an attribute?	Practice
Count on your fingers	**The Ben Ish Chai**, based on **the Arizal**	**Yes** — the first **ה'** is attribute 1, the second **ה'** is attribute 2	Count each attribute on a finger as you say it
Don't count	**Chacham Ovadia Yosef**	It is a **big מחלוקת ראשונים** how to count them	Just say them, with in mind *"whatever the 13 are, the 13 are"* — don't start thinking "1, 2, 3, 4…"
The Rambam and Onkelos	This chapter	**No — on all four readings.** On 1–3 the first ה' is the one *calling*; on 4 the doubling is not really part of the attributes	The attributes start from the second **ה'**

The Rabbi used to count them on his fingers — and stopped, when he came across this. Chacham Ovadia's position is totally logical: the Arizal held that way, fine — but look at the Rishonim, and all the different ways of reading the verse we've now seen.

His main point: we have seen clearly that **the Rambam does not count the first ה'** as an attribute of mercy — **and neither does Onkelos.** So if you count on your fingers starting from the first **ה'**, you are going against the Rambam and against Onkelos. *If you're convinced the Arizal and the Ben Ish Chai are right, fine, do that — "then you probably wouldn't be coming to these shiurim!"* Otherwise: **just have in mind that whatever the 13 attributes are, they are the 13 attributes.**

Part Five — Loose Ends: עבירה, המעביר על מדותיו, and Doron's Question

עבירה — overreach

Doron raised this last time: is **עבירה** meaning 4 (overreaching) or 5 (diverting)?

Rabbi Sacks — beautifully, in his usual beautiful way — says **עבירה is meaning 4: an overreach.** A sin is, essentially, **going beyond what we are meant to be doing** — beyond the boundaries, beyond where we are meant to be in life.

So meaning 4 finally finds its use. We used meanings 5, 1, 3 and 2 in the four interpretations — **never 4**. Now we see that **4 is the meaning behind the concept of sin.**

כל המעביר על מדותיו מעבירין לו על כל פשעיו

The famous statement of the Chachamim (Rosh Hashanah 17a): **whoever "passes over" his middot, all his sins are "passed over."** When people insult you and you are not strict in judgment — when you **overlook** what others do to you — God overlooks what you do wrong to Him.

Which meaning of עבר is מעביר? Certainly not physical passing (1), not proclamation (2), not a prophetic vision (3). **It's 4 or 5.**

	Meaning 4 — overreach	Meaning 5 — diversion
המעביר על מדותיו	Your middot are telling you to take retribution, to stand up, to be angry, to take revenge — and you **pass that over**; you overreach it. *I'm going to ignore those middot*	You **divert** from your middot — from being strict in judgment — like the Rambam interpreted **ויעבר**
מעבירין לו על כל פשעיו	Your sins, which are meant to be connected to you — **we overreach them from you**; we say they're not part of you	**We divert from you all your sins**
The Rabbi	His first thought: *"it must be four, really"*	*"Probably better is number five"* — and that is certainly the best reading of the second half

The lesson: what we're learning gives us **utensils** to understand many statements. All the verbs we have learned over these 21 chapters can be applied to other statements of the Chachamim. **Try to remember and apply what we've learned.**

Doron's question: "I will remove My palm"

Doron, on the Rambam's first reading: the Rabbi had said there was a problem with **ושכתי כפי... והסרתי את כפי**. The difficulty: if **כפי** is intellectual protection during the diversion, why does the verse say *I will remove My protection, and then you shall see My back*?

	The Rabbi's first answer	Doron's reading
ושכתי כפי עליך עד עברי	I will protect you **until** I finish the diversion	The protection is needed **until the diversion is complete** — during it, he hasn't yet fully seen the back
והסרתי את כפי	Once the diversion finishes, I remove the intellectual protection	Once I've finished the diversion and given you the **כלים** not to fall into trying to penetrate My face, the protection is no longer needed
וראית את אחרי	*And you will have seen My back* — past tense	**Now you can focus on the back freely** — think about the Thirteen Attributes freely. **אחורי** isn't something seen once in the past: it's **going forward, throughout your whole life's experience** — the way I conduct Myself
Verdict	*"Both make sense"*	*"Very nice, beautiful… probably yours is actually better."*

The danger is in the diversion itself: taking someone away from trying to penetrate God's face, towards His back. Once that is done, there is no more danger in contemplating the back.

Summary of Chapter 21

Over three shiurim (the end of the one two weeks ago, last week and this week), we went through **the five meanings of עבר** and applied them to **four interpretations** of **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא** and the whole passage — with ramifications for how to read the verses, how to divide them, the טעמים, bowing, and counting the attributes.

The main thing: do not think God passed Moshe. That is impossible, because God has no body and God has no face.

Part Six — Chapter 22: בא, "To Come"

A much easier, more straightforward, very short chapter. The Rambam continues his theme throughout these chapters: **multi-meaning verbs** that the Torah uses of Hashem.

Why בא, and why now?

Explanation	The connection to Chapter 21
Rav Makbili	In the same chapter of the Torah as **ויעבר ה' על פניו** (Shemot 34), about 20–30 verses later, it says (34:34) **ובבא משה לפני ה' לדבר אתו** — *when Moshe came before Hashem to speak with Him*. So having discussed one multi-meaning verb from that chapter, the Rambam discusses another: **בא**.
The Rabbi's own suggestion	See the end of the chapter: **the Rambam himself adds a word** here. In Chapter 21 he accepted Onkelos's method of adding words; now he shows that **he does it too**.

The four meanings of בא

.means four things — "really three," since the fourth is an extension of the third **הביאה בלשון עברית**

#	Meaning	Example	Physical?	Onkelos (Rav Kapach)
1	**Coming to** a place or a person	**בא אחיך במרמה** (Bereishit 27:35) — Yaakov literally came, from one place to another	**Yes** — physical, geographical	**אתא** (*he came*)
2	**Coming into** an enclosed place	**ויבא יוסף הביתה** (Bereishit 43:26); **כי תבאו אל הארץ** — into an enclosed geographical place	**Yes** — physical, geographical	**על** (*he entered*)
3	**The "coming" of something entirely non-corporeal** — i.e. it **happens**	**כי יבא דבריך וכבדנוך** (Shoftim 13:17); **מאשר יבאו עליך** (Yeshayahu 47:13)	**No**	—
4	**Extended even to a privation** — the "happening" of something that isn't really there	**ויבא רע... ויבא אפל** (Iyov 30:26)	**No**	—

Meaning 1 — coming to

נקבע לביאת בעל חיים, כלומר לגישתו למקום מסוים או לפרט אחר: בא אחיך במרמה.

Any creature coming to somewhere. *(We'll read it in Parashat Toldot in a couple of weeks.)* **Your brother came** — he literally came.

Meaning 2 — coming into

עוד נקבע לכניסת בעל חיים למקום מסוים. Don't mix 1 and 2: **1** is just coming *to* a place; **2** is coming *into* somewhere — Yosef came **into** the house; Bnei Yisrael will come **into** the land.

Rav Kapach's observation: whenever the Torah means meaning 1, **Targum** uses **אתא** (alef-tav-alef); whenever it means coming into an enclosed place, meaning 2, Targum uses **על** (ayin-lamed). *"All these years I never realized this when I read the Targum — but now, beautiful. Now I'm looking out for this all the time."*

Meaning 3 — something non-corporeal "comes": it happens

הושאל לחלותו של דבר שאינו גשמי כלל.

Manoach and his wife ask the **מלאך ה'**: tell us your name, so that **when your words come** — when we have the baby boy, Shimshon — we may honour you. **Words don't come.** They don't come to a place or into a place. It means: when something non-corporeal **is manifested in a happening**.

Yeshayahu mocks those who go to the astrologers, the stars, the avodah zarah: **יעמדו נא ויושיעך הברי שמים, החזים בכוכבים, מודיעם לחדשים מאשר יבאו עליך** — let them tell you **what will come upon you**. Nothing is coming onto you geographically: **it's a happening.**

Meaning 4 — even a privation

עד כדי כך שהושאל להעדר מסוים: ויבא רע, ויבא אפל.

The Rambam holds that there is no such thing as bad, and no such thing as darkness — we'll discuss this much later in the Moreh. Bad, darkness and evil are all **privations** (**העדר**), all **lackings** — not creations. Yet the verse says *bad came, darkness came* — it happened — even though these things never really "come," since they are only a privation. **בא can be extended even that far.**

There are even halachic ramifications. A famous piece of **Rav Elchanan Wasserman**: is darkness a creation, or a privation? When it says **ויהי ערב ויהי בקר**, does **ערב** mean a creation of evening and darkness — or simply a privation, a lack of light, a lack of day? **The Rambam holds it's the latter: not a creation, but a privation.**

When בא is used of Hashem: always meaning 3

בהתאם להשאלה זו — שהוראתה שהתרחש דבר מה בכלל — הושאל גם לגבי תוארו יתרומם: אם לחלות הגעת דברו, או לחלות השראת שכינתו.

Whenever the Torah says Hashem "comes," it can't mean 1 or 2 — He has no physicality — and it can't mean 4. **It must be meaning 3**, and it means one of two things:

Hashem "coming" means…	Example	Explanation
The resting of His Shechinah	**הנה אנכי בא אליך בעב הענן** (Shemot 19:9) at Har Sinai, Parashat Yitro	*I am resting My Shechinah on you* **in the thickness of a cloud**. **Rav Makbili: בעב הענן** = in **the thickness and cloudiness of human nature** — even though a human is made of **חומר**, of thickness and corporeality, I will still rest My presence amongst you and upon you
The resting of His Shechinah	**השער הזה סגור יהיה, לא יפתח, ואיש לא יבא בו, כי ה' אלהי ישראל בא בו** (Yechezkel 44:2)	The gate of the **Third Temple** will be closed until Hashem "comes in it" — until He decides to **rest His Shechinah** there
The fulfillment of His word	**ובא ה' אלהי כל קדשים עמך** (Zechariah 14:5)	**חלות דברו — כלומר, קיום הבטחותיו שהבטיח ביד נביאיו.** The promises He made through His prophets **will come** — will happen

The Rambam adds a word

On Zechariah, the Rambam writes: **כאלו אמר: ובא דבר ה' אלהי על ידי כל קדשים עמך** — *as if the verse said, the word of Hashem my God will come through all the holy ones with you* — i.e., through **the prophets** amongst Yisrael. **His words will be fulfilled; His prophecies will be accomplished.**

Notice: the Rambam has to add words here. It's not so clean; he struggles a bit. **And that, perhaps, is the connection between this chapter and Chapter 21.** In Chapter 21 the Rambam had his preferred reading of **ויעבר**, which needed no added word — but he said of Onkelos's method, *"I'll accept that."* Here he shows that **he isn't, in principle, against the method of Rav Saadia and Targum Onkelos of adding words: he does it himself.** *"Even according to my own interpretation, I agree that sometimes I do need to add in words."*

And ביאה?

What about ביאה in the sense of intercourse? The Torah itself uses **בא** this way — **ובא אליה**. **The Rabbi:** that must be **meaning 2** — a physical **coming into**: geographical, physical, but *into*.

Summary of Chapter 22

Meaning	Physical?	Used of Hashem?
1 — coming to a place	Yes	Never
2 — coming into a place *(and ביאה)*	Yes	Never
3 — a non-corporeal happening	No	**Always** — the resting of His **Shechinah**, or the **fulfillment of His word** through the prophets
4 — even a privation (**ויבא רע, ויבא אפל**)	No	No

Whenever we talk about בא in the context of HaKadosh Baruch Hu, it means number three: non-corporeal. *"A very straightforward chapter."*

Summary

Chapter 21 complete:

- **Interpretation 4: ויעבר קול ה' על פניו, ויקרא** — the Rambam uses Onkelos's principle of adding a word, but adds **קול**: a created voice reverberated in Moshe's presence (**2 עבר**), and the **voice** called **"ה' ה"** — **the only reading with a doubled ה'**, like **משה משה**. A voice can call, just as **וישמע את הקול מדבר אליו**.
- **The Rambam's conclusion: בחר איזה דעה שתחפוץ** — choose any of the four — **but never think God Himself physically passed**, because He has no body and no movement.
- **Rav Makbili's ladder:** reading **1** is the highest (intellect alone); **2** the lowest (sight of a created glory); **3** (prophecy) and **4** (hearing — subtle) in between.
- **The four questions: פניו** ;2 / 3 / 1 / 5 = עבר = God's face only on reading 1, Moshe's on 2–4; **ויקרא ה'** on 1–3, **ויקרא: ה' ה'** on 4 (which the טעמים favour — Ibn Ezra's question on Rav Saadia); and **no reading counts the first ה' as an attribute** — so, with Chacham Ovadia, **don't count them on your fingers**.
  or, probably better, 5; and **Doron's** 4 = **המעביר על מדותיו** ;overreach (meaning 4, Rabbi Sacks) = **עבירה** the danger is in the diversion — afterwards you see the back freely, all your :**reading** of **והסרתי את כפי** .life

Chapter 22: (1) = **בא** coming to; (2) coming into (Onkelos: **אתא** vs **על**); (3) a non-corporeal happening; (4) even a privation. **Of Hashem it always means 3** — His Shechinah resting, or His word fulfilled — and the Rambam himself adds a word to explain **ובא ה' אלהי כל קדשים עמך**.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** three short chapters — **23**, **24** and, b'ezrat Hashem, **25**.
- **Chapter 23:** the opposite of coming — **יציאה**, *going out*.
- **Chapter 24:** another word for going — **הלוך / הליכה**.
- **Chapter 25: שכינה**.
- **During the week:** reflect on it and think about it. *These are very deep things. The shiur is an hour, but the Rabbi prepares many hours for each one — so it's important to go over it and review.* And next time you say **ויעבר ה' על פניו ויקרא**, choose your reading.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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